

Pain Assessment Tools

Match the tool to age, communication ability, cognition, and setting; reassessment completes the cycle.

Self-report tools - Numeric rating scale for clients who can quantify pain. - Verbal descriptor scale when words fit better than numbers. - Faces scales can support selected children and adults.	Behavior tools - Use a validated behavioral scale when self-report is not possible. - Behavior does not prove absence or presence by itself. - Ask family about baseline expressions when appropriate.
PQRST plus function - Provokes/palliates, Quality, Region/radiation, Severity, Timing. - Add functional goal, associated symptoms, and safety risks. - Reassess after every intervention at the required interval.	

Reviewed 2026-07-13 - Source: National Council of State Boards of Nursing - <https://www.ncsbn.org/publications/2026-nclex-pn-test-plan>
Study aid only. Verify current references, instructor guidance, scope, orders, and facility policy.